

Research Statement

My research examines political violence and international security, with a particular focus on forced migration, wartime legacies, and conflict diffusion. This agenda develops along two connected lines. The first examines how states, non-state armed actors, and international organizations respond to wartime population movements through refugee policy, public-service provision, and humanitarian assistance—and how these responses affect conflict and stability. The second investigates how wartime exposure and information about prior conflicts influence subsequent political behavior. It identifies the conditions under which shared experiences of violence facilitate postwar reconciliation, how conflict narratives transmitted across borders affect support for future violence, and how armed groups draw inferences from prior military experience when deciding whether to initiate new conflicts. Together, these lines explain why the disruptions of war sometimes contribute to peace but at other times reproduce or spread conflict. I investigate these questions using original cross-national data and subnational and individual-level evidence from the Middle East, Africa, and Asia, combining observational research designs, survey experiments, and text analysis. Across projects, I pursue credible causal identification while examining whether the findings generalize across countries and conflict settings.

At the center of this research agenda is my dissertation, which asks why wartime displacement contributes to stability in some settings but intensifies violence in others. Examining refugee hosting, refugee return, and war-time internal displacement, I argue that the consequences of population movement depend not on displacement alone but on the policies, social relationships, and strategic decisions through which it is governed. Across the three papers, I show how refugee rights condition the local effects of international assistance, how shared wartime experiences affect postwar reintegration, and how governments use public-service provision to manage civilian movement during conflict.

The first paper examines how international assistance and host-country refugee policies jointly affect conflict in refugee-hosting communities across the Global South. Donors often provide aid to communities receiving large refugee populations both to support host countries and to reduce pressure for onward migration to the Global North. I argue that this assistance is most likely to promote stability when refugees have access to employment and freedom of movement. These rights allow refugees to participate in local economies and extend the economic benefits of aid beyond refugee settlements and humanitarian organizations. When host governments restrict refugees' mobility and economic participation, aid may instead reinforce inequalities between refugees and local residents and increase grievances. Using multiple identification strategies and evidence from subnational conflict data, individual surveys, and evaluations of aid projects, I find consistent support for the argument. This paper received **the Dina Zinnes Award for Best Graduate Student Paper** from the Scientific Study of International Processes (SSIP) section of the International Studies Association (ISA).

The second paper of my dissertation—my job-market paper—examines the reintegration of returning refugees into war-affected communities. Although return is often treated as the natural endpoint of displacement, recent research documents tensions between returnees and those who remained during the conflict, or “stayees.” Existing accounts emphasize competition over resources and suspicions about returnees' wartime loyalties, but they do not fully explain why return produces reconciliation in some communities and renewed conflict in others. I argue that reintegration depends on whether returnees and stayees experienced similar forms of wartime violence. Shared exposure can foster empathy and a common survivor identity, reducing communal tensions. When their wartime experiences differ substantially, however, return may reactivate grievances, reinforce social divisions, and heighten fears of retaliation. I evaluate this argument using evidence from post-ISIS Iraq and postwar Ethiopia. In Iraq, I combine fine-grained conflict-event records with village-level surveys from the International Organization for

Migration. I find that the return of refugees from ISIS-affected host countries reduces communal clashes in communities that also endured ISIS rule but increases instability in communities without comparable wartime experiences. I then use an original conjoint survey experiment in Ethiopia to test whether shared exposure increases empathy, strengthens a common identity, and builds support for reintegration. Combining evidence of community-level conflict with an experiment designed to isolate the proposed mechanisms allows me to examine both when shared wartime exposure matters and why. This paper explains why refugee return can consolidate peace in some war-affected communities but reignite conflict in others. More broadly, it shows that wartime victimization does not uniformly perpetuate division: when groups understand their suffering as shared, exposure to violence can provide a basis for postwar reconciliation. The project connects the two broader lines of my research agenda by showing how wartime legacies create social boundaries that condition the consequences of population movement.

The final paper of my dissertation turns to internal displacement during ongoing conflict and examines how governments use public-service provision to influence where displaced civilians settle. Because internally displaced persons remain within the country, their movement can alter rebel recruitment, civilian support, and territorial control. I argue that governments may provide public services even to politically disloyal populations in contested areas when their movement into government strongholds would strain local capacity and increase the risk that instability spreads to those areas. A formal model specifies the conditions under which this incentive arises. I evaluate the argument during the 2020–2024 Amhara insurgency in Ethiopia, using an event-study design that examines changes in public-service provision to displaced Amhara populations as their relationship with the federal government shifted from alliance to armed opposition. The analysis draws on settlement-level assessments conducted by the International Organization for Migration. The paper shows that humanitarian assistance can serve not only as a response to civilian need or a means of cultivating loyalty, but also as an instrument for managing population movement during war. It thereby connects internal displacement to rebel constituencies, territorial control, and the geographic spread of conflict.

Extending my research on the legacies of violence beyond displaced populations, I also examine how armed actors interpret past battles and how those lessons shape future conflict. In a lead-authored article accepted at *International Studies Quarterly*, we investigate when experience in one conflict encourages armed actors to initiate another. Conventional theories emphasize uncertainty about actors' relative capabilities but often assume that this uncertainty applies similarly across different types of warfare. We instead examine a common situation in insurgencies: rebel groups may know their capabilities in familiar guerrilla warfare but remain uncertain about whether those capabilities will translate into conventional operations, such as capturing and holding major cities. Our formal model therefore distinguishes between an initial conflict fought under complete information and a different conflict initiated under incomplete information. It shows that victory in a familiar form of warfare may provide misleading lessons about an actor's prospects in an unfamiliar one, encouraging escalation into a costly conflict that it might otherwise avoid. We illustrate this process through the Shining Path insurgency in Peru. The article advances the second line of my research agenda by showing how the legacies of past conflict shape future violence: just as civilians' interpretations of shared wartime suffering can facilitate or obstruct reconciliation, armed actors' interpretations of previous victories can either preserve peace or encourage renewed conflict.

In addition to formal modeling, my research uses survey experiments, computational methods, and cross-national and regional analyses to study public attitudes toward violence and security and governments' management of information, with particular attention to the Asia-Pacific and Middle East. In a coauthored article under revision at *Political Psychology*, we use a survey experiment in China to examine how logical fallacies in nationalist and geopolitical narratives shape belief in misinformation and whether targeted training can reduce these effects.

Our AI-generated short-video intervention produces especially strong corrective effects for misinformation based on personal attacks and hasty generalizations. A lead-authored working paper under review extends my research on displacement and conflict by showing that the positive association between refugee hosting and recorded violence may partly reflect improved monitoring and reporting capacity following refugee arrivals. Using media-source diversity, human- and LLM-coded information richness in ACLED, and evidence from Afghanistan, we show how displacement can reshape the visibility of low-intensity violence and social unrest. A third project examines how governments strategically portray human rights conditions when repatriating refugees. I argue that host countries may downplay abuses in refugees' countries of origin to justify return and facilitate cooperation with receiving governments. Using text-as-data and machine-learning methods, I compare government and independent human rights reports with refugee return flows to test this argument. Together, these projects extend both lines of my research agenda by examining how information infrastructure, strategic manipulation, and misinformation correction shape public responses to conflict and security as well as government responses to displacement.

I also broaden my research on conflict diffusion by examining how emerging technologies enable foreign fighters to transmit wartime experiences across distance and shape public attitudes toward violence and security. Existing research focuses primarily on their international recruitment, participation in protracted conflicts, and the security challenges associated with their return. Much less is known about how foreign fighters communicate their battlefield experiences through social media and thereby influence political attitudes in their countries of origin. Digital platforms have facilitated not only the recruitment of fighters in conflicts involving ISIS and the Russia–Ukraine war but also the circulation of their personal accounts, daily lives, and combat experiences among ordinary audiences. In a lead-authored work in progress, I examine this understudied channel of diffusion through the case of Chinese foreign fighters in the Russia–Ukraine war. I plan to preregister and field a survey experiment testing how short-form videos posted by foreign fighters—depicting their daily lives and combat experiences—shape domestic audiences' perceptions of violence and attitudes toward a potential cross-Strait conflict. The project extends my research on the legacies of war by connecting the physical movement of fighters across borders with the digital transmission of their experiences. It thereby explains how participation in a distant war can influence public support for violence in a different geopolitical context.

Finally, I plan to extend the central theme of my third dissertation chapter on wartime public goods provision by examining how governments manage critical infrastructure during wartime, including by sabotaging rather than strengthening it. In a joint work in progress, we develop a formal model of “strategic sabotage,” in which wartime actors destroy critical infrastructure, such as railroads and dams, to increase their likelihood of victory at the cost of reducing the value of what they may ultimately win. We show that sabotage is not only a weapon of the weak but may also be preferred by stronger actors, making it an unreliable signal of an actor's strength. Moreover, although sabotage reduces the value of the contested prize, it can improve welfare by alleviating commitment problems: by limiting future shifts in power, sabotage may increase the prospects for peace. We illustrate these counterintuitive findings with examples from the Second Sino-Japanese War and the Russia–Ukraine war.

Together, these projects form a cohesive research agenda demonstrating that renewed violence is not an inevitable consequence of displacement or wartime disruption. Instead, it emerges from the policies, social boundaries, and strategic choices that shape how states, armed groups, and communities respond to war. By bringing together research on forced displacement, conflict diffusion, and wartime governance, I identify when these responses transform wartime disruption into durable peace—and when they instead transmit violence across communities, borders, and social groups.